12 Expert Tips · April 2026

# How to use GitHub Copilot better than 99% of people

Agent Mode, Cloud Agent, MCP Servers, Copilot SDK, and the features most developers don't know exist.

⚡

IDE · AGENT MODE

# Switch to Agent Mode — stop using plain chat

Agent mode doesn't just suggest code. It edits files, runs terminal commands, installs packages, and fixes errors — all autonomously.

- Open Copilot Chat → switch dropdown to **Agent**
- Describe *what* you want, not *how* to build it
- Creates files, runs tests, fixes failures in a loop

```
// One prompt in Agent mode:
> "Add a /health endpoint with tests"

✓ Created src/routes/health.ts
✓ Created tests/health.test.ts
✓ Ran npm test — 3 passed
```

📖 docs.github.com/en/copilot 🚀 github.com/features/copilot

> *“Chat answers questions. Agent ships features.”*

🤖

CLOUD AGENT

# Assign issues directly to Copilot

Copilot Cloud Agent runs in the background on GitHub — no IDE needed. Assign an issue and it opens a PR.

📋 Open Issue → 🤖 Copilot Researches & Codes → 🔀 PR Created + CI Runs

- Open any issue → Assignees → select **Copilot**
- Agent signs its commits and runs your CI
- Works entirely in the cloud — zero IDE time

📖 Cloud Agent Guide  📖 Creating PRs with Copilot

> *"Your backlog now has an AI teammate."*

CONFIG

# Add custom instructions — once

One file in your repo. Every Copilot session reads it automatically — your coding standards applied every time.

```
.github/copilot-instructions.md
.github/instructions/*.instructions.md
AGENTS.md
```

- Define language, framework, and testing conventions
- Path-specific instructions with glob patterns
- Org-level instructions now GA (April 2026)
- Works across IDE, Cloud Agent, and CLI

Custom Instructions Docs

> *"Write your rules once. They apply forever."*

🔗 SECTION A · AGENTIC WORKFLOWS

# Explore More — Tips 01–03

Scan a QR code or tap a link to go deeper on Agent Mode, Cloud Agent, and Custom Instructions.

**GitHub Copilot Docs**
Official documentation hub — all features
docs.github.com/en/copilot

**Cloud Agent Guide**
Assign issues, create PRs, track sessions
docs.github.com/.../cloud-agent

**Custom Instructions**
Repo-wide, path-specific, and org-level instructions
docs.github.com/.../add-repository-instructions

**Copilot Features Page**
Official feature overview & pricing
github.com/features/copilot

**Creating PRs with Copilot**
Step-by-step guide to automated PR creation
docs.github.com/.../create-a-pr

**Full Cheatsheet**
Complete reference guide — all 12 tips in detail
sendtoshailesh.github.io/copilot-cheatsheet/...

🧠

MODEL SELECTION

# Pick the right model for the job

Click the model picker in VS Code or on GitHub. Match the model to the task.

🏗 **COMPLEX TASKS**

**Claude Opus 4.7** — deep refactors
**GPT-5.4** — large architecture

⚡ **QUICK TASKS**

**GPT-5.4 mini** — fast & cheap
**Gemini Flash** — high volume

- Switch models mid-conversation anytime
- Each model has a premium request multiplier
- CLI supports BYOK & local models (Ollama)

📖 Models & Billing

> *“The best model is the one that fits the task.”*

PROMPT FILES

# Create reusable prompt files

Store task-specific prompts as Markdown files. Invoke them with / slash command. Shareable across your entire team.

```
.github/prompts/code-review.md
.github/prompts/add-tests.md
.github/prompts/refactor.md
.github/prompts/deploy-checklist.md
```

- One file per workflow: review, deploy, migrate, document
- Include variables, constraints, and output format
- Team members use the same prompts for consistency

📖 Custom Instructions & Prompts

> *"One great prompt file > 50 random asks."*

MCP SERVERS

# Connect external tools via MCP

Model Context Protocol lets Copilot talk to databases, APIs, Docker, Azure, and 50+ integrations mid-conversation.

Copilot ↔ MCP Protocol ↔ DBs · APIs · Cloud

```
.vscode/mcp.json
```

- Org admins can manage MCP allow-lists for security
- Copilot reads real data from your systems at runtime
- No more copy-pasting context into prompts

MCP with Cloud Agent  github/github-mcp-server

> *“Copilot stops being autocomplete. Starts being infrastructure.”*

🔗 SECTION B · CONFIGURATION & CONTEXT

# Explore More — Tips 04–06

Scan a QR code or tap a link to go deeper on Model Selection, Prompt Files, and MCP Servers.

**Models & Premium Requests**
Understand model costs and billing
docs.github.com/.../copilot-requests

**Instructions & Prompts**
Repo-wide, path-specific, and prompt files
docs.github.com/.../add-repository-instructions

**MCP with Cloud Agent**
Extend Copilot with Model Context Protocol
docs.github.com/.../extend-cloud-agent-with-mcp

**GitHub MCP Server**
Official MCP server for GitHub APIs
github.com/github/github-mcp-server

**MCP Management & Policies**
Org-level MCP governance settings
docs.github.com/.../mcp-management

**Full Cheatsheet**
Complete reference guide — all 12 tips in detail
sendtoshailesh.github.io/copilot-cheatsheet/...

🖥️

CLI

# Copilot CLI — AI in your terminal

Run `copilot` from any terminal. It makes changes, creates PRs, runs commands — all with your approval.

- Interactive mode + programmatic mode with –p
- Supports BYOK and local models (Ollama)
- Plan mode: Shift+Tab to build a plan before coding

```
$ copilot
> "Add a /health endpoint with tests and open a PR"

✓ Created src/routes/health.ts
✓ Ran npm test – passed
✓ Opened PR #42
```

📖 About Copilot CLI  📖 Install Guide

> *“Stop Googling terminal commands.”*

🔍

IDE SHORTCUTS

# Master @workspace, @terminal, and slash commands

Give Copilot full repo context with **@workspace**. Use **@terminal** for CLI help. Fire off instant actions.

```
@workspace "how does auth work?"
@terminal "why did that test fail?"
/fix → auto-fixes selected code
/tests → generates unit tests
/explain → explains code in detail
/doc → adds documentation
```

📖 Copilot Docs

> *“Shortcuts beat paragraphs. Every time.”*

📝

CODE REVIEW

# Let Copilot review your pull requests

Copilot Code Review catches bugs, security issues, and style violations before human reviewers even look.

📤 Push PR → 🤖 Copilot Reviews → ✅ Fix & Merge

- Enable in repo → Copilot → Code Review
- Catches security vulnerabilities automatically
- Customize with .github/copilot-instructions.md
- Enable automatic reviews for all PRs

📖 Copilot Code Review Docs

> *"AI catches what humans miss. Before merge."*

🔗 SECTION C · DAILY WORKFLOW

# Explore More — Tips 07–09

Scan a QR code or tap a link to go deeper on Copilot CLI, IDE Shortcuts, and Code Review.

**About Copilot CLI**
Interactive & programmatic modes, use cases
docs.github.com/.../about-copilot-cli

**Install Copilot CLI**
Step-by-step setup guide
docs.github.com/.../install-copilot-cli

**Copilot Code Review**
Automatic reviews, suggested changes, custom rules
docs.github.com/.../use-code-review

**GitHub Copilot Blog**
Latest announcements and deep dives
github.blog/category/product/copilot/

**Copilot Docs Hub**
Complete documentation — all features
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**Full Cheatsheet**
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SDK · SKILLS · EXTENSIONS

# Build with Agent Skills & Extensions

Create custom agent skills, VS Code extensions powered by Copilot, and internal developer tools.

**🛠️ AGENT SKILLS**

Custom instructions + scripts
Enhance Cloud Agent abilities
Manage via GitHub CLI

**🧩 COPILOT EXTENSIONS**

VS Code extensions with AI
Custom chat participants
Build internal tools

- Copilot is a platform, not just a tool
- Create specialized agents for your team's workflows

📖 Agent Skills Docs

> *“Copilot isn't just a tool. It's a platform.”*

🏢

ENTERPRISE

# Configure org-level governance

Granular enterprise controls: runner settings, firewall, custom properties, audit logs, and data residency.

- Org runner controls for Cloud Agent (April 2026)
- Firewall settings to control agent network access
- MCP server allow-lists per organization
- Data residency in US + EU — FedRAMP compliant

📖 Agent Settings

> *“Power without governance is chaos.”*

BEST PRACTICE

# Your repo IS Copilot's brain

Copilot's output quality is proportional to your repo quality. Clean structure, good README, and consistent patterns matter.

**❌ MESSY REPO**

No README or docs
Inconsistent naming
Flat file structure
→ Weak suggestions

**✅ CLEAN REPO**

Detailed README.md
Consistent conventions
Logical folder structure
→ Precise suggestions

- Write a solid README — it's the first thing Copilot reads
- Use **Copilot Spaces** to share curated context

📖 Copilot Best Practices

> *"Garbage repo in, garbage suggestions out."*

🔗 SECTION D · PLATFORM & GOVERNANCE

# Explore More — Tips 10–12

Scan a QR code or tap a link to go deeper on SDK/Skills, Enterprise Governance, and Repo Best Practices.

**Agent Skills**
Add custom skills to enhance Copilot
docs.github.com/.../add-skills

**Agent Settings**
Org-level configuration & policies
docs.github.com/.../configuring-agent-settings

**Copilot Docs Hub**
Complete documentation — all features
docs.github.com/en/copilot

**Copilot Features Page**
Official feature overview & pricing
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**GitHub Copilot Blog**
Latest announcements and deep dives
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**Full Cheatsheet**
Complete reference guide — all 12 tips in detail
sendtoshailesh.github.io/copilot-cheatsheet/...

# Stop using Copilot like autocomplete.

These 12 features separate the top 1% from everyone else. The gap is only getting wider.

Scan for Full Cheatsheet

**Full Cheatsheet →**

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#GitHubCopilot #AI #DeveloperProductivity #CopilotAgent #SoftwareEngineering #DevTools #GitHub